ZURICH, SWITZERLAND

Museum Rietberg: Masterpieces

Twenty Chinese paintings read through rivers, mist, scale and the shape of the sheet.



Open paper is not an absence of landscape. In this selection it can carry a river, separate a terrace from a mountain or give a small boat enough room to appear solitary. The inked areas work in relation to those intervals: a densely described bank makes the water beside it more expansive, while a dark contour can establish snow without painting its entire surface.

The works come from the Rietberg's Chinese painting holdings associated with the Drenowatz collection. Several are album leaves, and two use the curved field of a fan. Those formats matter. These are bounded surfaces with different ways of accommodating a journey, not interchangeable windows onto a single kind of scenery.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/museum-rietberg

The selection · 20

1. Evening by the Jade River
   Mei Qing · Qing dynasty, dated 1680
2. Old Man on a Mule
   Attributed to Gao Qipei · Qing dynasty
3. Seeking the Immortals in the Magu Mountains
   Mei Qing · Qing dynasty, dated 1680
4. On the Terrace of Returning Spring
   Mei Qing · Qing dynasty, dated 1680
5. Bamboo and Rocks
   Hongren · Qing dynasty, 1656
6. Bamboo Grove on a Cliff
   Hongren · Qing dynasty, 1656
7. Viewing the Waterfall
   Shen Hao · Ming or Qing dynasty, c. 1640
8. Mountain in the Manner of Huang Gongwang
   Gu Shanyou · Ming dynasty, dated 1639
9. Mountains and Peaks
   Zhang Zongcang · Qing dynasty, dated 1748
10. Bodhidharma Crossing the Yangzi on a Reed
    Ding Yunpeng · 1574
11. Boat by a Bank with Weeping Willows
    Gu Shanyou · Ming dynasty, dated 1639
12. Mount Lingyan after Snowfall
    Unknown artist · Ming dynasty, dated 1643
13. Composing Poetry in a Boat beneath a Pine
    Shen Hao · Ming or Qing dynasty, c. 1640
14. A Scholar Viewing a Waterfall
    Li Liufang · Ming dynasty, dated 1617
15. A Solitary Fisherman
    Wang Jiu · Qing dynasty, dated 1759
16. A Solitary Fisherman on the River
    Hongren · Qing dynasty, 1656
17. A Solitary Temple in the Mountains
    Gu Shanyou · Ming dynasty, dated 1639
18. A Solitary Traveller in a Misty Landscape
    Zhang Zongcang · Qing dynasty, dated 1748
19. A Solitary House in a Marshy River Landscape
    Kuncan · Qing dynasty, 17th century
20. River Landscape
    Dong Qichang · Ming dynasty, dated 1624

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Evening by the Jade River

Mei Qing

Qing dynasty, dated 1680 · Ink and colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Mei Qing; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The river occupies a pale interval between more worked banks. Buildings and distant ridges establish places along it without requiring equal detail throughout. In this leaf from *Views of Xuancheng*, the contrast gives water its breadth. Writing and seals belong to the same sheet, whose space must accommodate more than landscape alone.

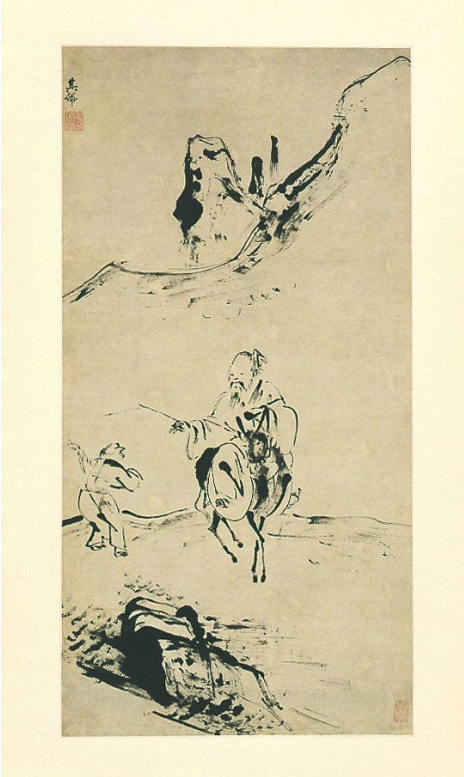
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1170d

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Old Man on a Mule

Attributed to Gao Qipei

Qing dynasty · Ink on paper · Museum Rietberg



zugeschrieben: Gao Qipei; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

A rider and attendant pass through a tall space with few marks to interrupt them. The branch and dark accents provide enough direction for the journey to register. The attribution to Gao Qipei remains qualified; the spareness of the design is something to examine, not evidence sufficient to turn an attributed work into a secure one.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1025

03 / 20

Seeking the Immortals in the Magu Mountains

Mei Qing

Qing dynasty, dated 1680 · Ink and colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Mei Qing; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The search named in the title takes a visible form in overlapping ridges, small buildings and a winding route. No single uninterrupted path explains the whole terrain. The eye has to pass from one mass to the next, making successive encounters within the compact leaf rather than taking possession of the landscape at once.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1170w

04 / 20

On the Terrace of Returning Spring

Mei Qing

Qing dynasty, dated 1680 · Ink and colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Mei Qing; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The terrace and its tree are near; the mountain is distant. Between them lies an interval with much less information. That separation does not break the picture in two. It makes distance an active relation, giving the small foreground position something extensive to face and leaving the passage across it largely unmarked.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1170p

05 / 20

Bamboo and Rocks

Hongren

Qing dynasty, 1656 · Ink on paper · Museum Rietberg



Hongren; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

Bamboo and rock are distinguished through the kinds of marks they receive. Pointed leaves gather around slender stems, while broken surfaces give the stone a different resistance. With little colour to separate the subjects, the hand’s change of action becomes especially clear. Open paper gives both room without supplying a detailed background.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1168j

06 / 20

Bamboo Grove on a Cliff

Hongren

Qing dynasty, 1656 · Ink on paper · Museum Rietberg



Hongren; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

A sharply defined cliff sets the small building and bamboo above the lower terrain. Architecture offers a measure of the change in height without taking over the scene. The contrast between hard edges and restrained surface detail makes the ascent intelligible: much can be left undescribed once the main divisions of ground are established.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1168h

07 / 20

Viewing the Waterfall

Shen Hao

Ming or Qing dynasty, c. 1640 · Ink and light colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Shen Hao; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The small figure on the ledge supplies a second act of viewing inside the picture. Its size gives the waterfall height, while pine and blue-grey rocks distinguish the surrounding spaces. The spectator can follow the figure’s position without needing to inhabit it literally; it is a measure placed within a much larger arrangement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1148d

08 / 20

Mountain in the Manner of Huang Gongwang

Gu Shanyou

Ming dynasty, dated 1639 · Ink and colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Gu Shanyou; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The title openly names Huang Gongwang as a point of reference, so the landscape should not be approached as an isolated invention. Buildings and layered slopes occupy one page while calligraphy faces them. The album presents looking and reading alongside one another, without making the written page merely a caption under an image.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1140b

09 / 20

Mountains and Peaks

Zhang Zongcang

Qing dynasty, dated 1748 · Ink and light colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Zhang Zongcang; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

Ridges recur with differences in their contour and density of ink. That variation prevents repetition from becoming a row of identical mountains. Small trees and buildings give intervals of scale within the larger masses. The upper inscription also claims part of the open field, keeping the landscape within the physical conditions of an inscribed leaf.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1162c

10 / 20

Bodhidharma Crossing the Yangzi on a Reed

Ding Yunpeng

1574 · Ink and colour on paper with silk mounting · Museum Rietberg



Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. RCH 1021; Ding Yunpeng; Bodhidharma Crossing the Yangzi River on a Reed; 1574. Complete source image proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no cropping. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The reed is an improbable support for the robed figure. Against the lightly described water, its smallness makes the legendary crossing intelligible as something beyond ordinary balance. The tall format gives the body room while withholding substantial footing. The subject's marvel is concentrated in that unequal relation rather than a crowded narrative.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1021

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Boat by a Bank with Weeping Willows

Gu Shanyou

Ming dynasty, dated 1639 · Ink and colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Gu Shanyou; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The boat stays near the shelter of slender trees, while hills extend beyond the bank. It is a modest point from which to consider a larger distance. A facing page of calligraphy also slows the encounter: the painting belongs to an album in which attention can alternate between different kinds of mark.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1140a

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Mount Lingyan after Snowfall

Unknown artist

Ming dynasty, dated 1643 · Ink and light colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

Snow is suggested by the pale areas left between dark trees and worked mountain contours. The picture does not need to cover the whole sheet in order to describe a covered landscape. The museum record does not establish an artist’s identity; that uncertainty leaves the method available to examine without attaching it to an invented biography.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1143

13 / 20

Composing Poetry in a Boat beneath a Pine

Shen Hao

Ming or Qing dynasty, c. 1640 · Ink and light colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Shen Hao; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The poem itself is not supplied by the seated figures. What is made visible is a situation for composing: a boat beneath an extending pine, with water separated from rock by light marks and colour. The branch provides shelter without filling the entire view. An intellectual activity receives a place rather than a literal illustration of its words.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1148b

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A Scholar Viewing a Waterfall

Li Liufang

Ming dynasty, dated 1617 · Ink on gold-ground paper · Museum Rietberg



Li Liufang; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The fan's boundary changes how much room the landscape has at different points. Small figures and trees occupy a field that widens outward and narrows below, unlike a rectangular sheet. The gold ground is part of that material setting. A waterfall view must be arranged within this shape, not simply cropped from an imagined unlimited scene.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1150

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A Solitary Fisherman

Wang Jiu

Qing dynasty, dated 1759 · Ink on paper · Museum Rietberg



Wang Jiu; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The river's pale course turns between densely marked banks. Its narrowing gives distance a direction, while the small boat provides a scale within it. Solitude is therefore a spatial relationship, not a biography assigned to the fisherman. There is considerably more terrain to attend to than human action.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1165d

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A Solitary Fisherman on the River

Hongren

Qing dynasty, 1656 · Ink on paper · Museum Rietberg



Hongren; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

Hongren distributes the scene in low, lightly marked stages rather than building a crowded wall of mountains. A boat remains visible in the broad water between banks and a pavilion. Compare this with Wang Jiu’s fisherman: both use open water, but the different pressure of surrounding ground changes the human figure’s relation to it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1168d

17 / 20

A Solitary Temple in the Mountains

Gu Shanyou

Ming dynasty, dated 1639 · Ink and colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Gu Shanyou; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The temple sits within the mountain’s overlapping forms rather than above them as a commanding landmark. Trees and pale distinctions of colour help separate its enclosing terrain. Seclusion can be understood through this arrangement alone: a small built place receives space inside a much larger landscape, without requiring a story about whoever occupies it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1140d

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A Solitary Traveller in a Misty Landscape

Zhang Zongcang

Qing dynasty, dated 1748 · Ink and light colour on paper · Museum Rietberg



Zhang Zongcang; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

Pale passages interrupt the more densely described ground between buildings, trees and distant ridges. Mist permits distances to be separated without drawing a hard boundary around each one. The traveller named by the title belongs to this alternation of clarity and concealment; the landscape cannot be read as a completely exposed route.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1162g

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A Solitary House in a Marshy River Landscape

Kuncan

Qing dynasty, 17th century · Fan leaf, ink and colour on gold-ground paper · Museum Rietberg



Kuncan; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

The curved field accommodates buildings, bank and water through changing densities of ink. More concentrated marks establish habitation; thinner passages allow the river to open out. The fan's interrupted lower boundary is not incidental to the result. It gives the extensive scene a particular shape and requires its distances to fit that surface.

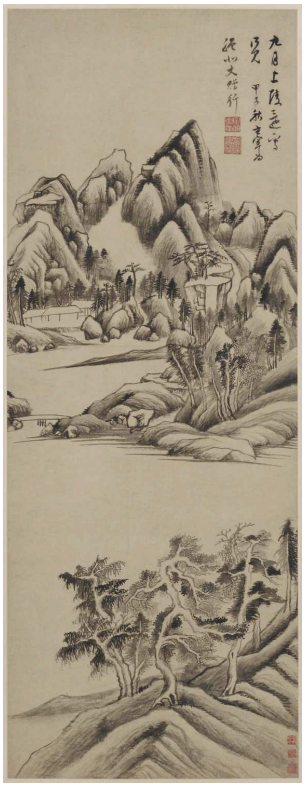
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1171

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River Landscape

Dong Qichang

Ming dynasty, dated 1624 · Ink on paper · Museum Rietberg



Dong Qichang; Museum Rietberg; Foto: Rainer Wolfensberger / Museum Rietberg. Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain (https://data.stadt-zuerich.ch/dataset/mrz_drenowatz_sammlung). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Museum Rietberg open data: image files public domain

Angular mountains stand above a broad pale river, with nearer banks and trees forming another stage below. The scene is connected by the spaces between these groups as much as by continuous lines. Following it requires shifts of attention among successive areas, while the inscription takes its own place in the upper field.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: RCH 1141

Compare the same subject across different sheets

The two fishermen offer a precise starting point: compare how much space surrounds each boat and how densely the banks are worked. Then compare a rectangular leaf with a fan. The museum's object records preserve distinctions between dated, attributed and unidentified works; retain them when following links or searching for reproductions. Check current displays separately.

Further reading

Along the Riverbank: Chinese Paintings from the C. C. Wang Family Collection

Maxwell K. Hearn and Wen C. Fong (1999) · Free PDF and online reading from the Metropolitan Museum of Art.

Hearn and Fong discuss landscape traditions, brushwork, attribution and the history of collecting through works at the Metropolitan Museum. The freely available catalogue offers further context for the older painters named in these album titles.

How to Read Chinese Paintings

Maxwell K. Hearn (2008) · Sample available through the publisher; full book in print.

This shorter introduction compares individual paintings and calligraphies in detail. The publisher offers a sample; access to the complete book requires a library or purchase.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12